御杖村プロジェクト概要 / Mitsue Village Project — Summary

One-Page Briefing for Mitsue Village Government
April 2026

What We Propose

To repurpose the closed **Mitsue Elementary School** (御杖小学校) as a **community sustainability center** that will:

1. Restore aging cedar (sugi) plantations to healthy native forest — native broadleaf trees feed local wildlife, reducing crop raids by deer, wild boar, and bear
2. Provide EV charging infrastructure and community backup power (privately owned solar + biomass-electric; battery storage subject to feasibility study)
3. House a small, low-impact data center powered by that local energy — a working model of progress and sustainability as a single coherent system

A 25-year initiative built carefully, in close partnership with the village.

Direct Benefits to Mitsue Village

- **Local employment** — forestry work, facility operations, maintenance roles
- **Income for landowners** — fair compensation to private mountain owners for sugi harvesting
- **Lower energy costs** — locally generated power for the village
- **EV charging infrastructure** — Mitsue prepared for the coming shift to electric vehicles
- **New use for the closed school** — preserving and honoring an important community building
- **Reduced cedar pollen** — gradual replacement of sugi with native species over decades
- **Reduced wildlife crop damage** — restored native forest provides natural food for deer, wild boar, and bear, keeping them out of agricultural areas
- **Broadband and digital infrastructure** — improved connectivity for residents and businesses
- **National and international visibility** — Mitsue as a model village for sustainable rural revitalization

Early Benefits — Visible Within Five Years

The 25-year horizon applies to forest restoration ecology. Concrete benefits to the village arrive much earlier:

Year	Tangible benefit to the village
1	Closed school building reactivated; village named in domestic and international press; first researcher and student visits
2	First forestry contracts → direct cash income to private mountain owners
2–3	Reduced sugi pollen and landslide risk in actively managed plots
3–4	EV charging stations operational; biomass-electric unit installed; battery storage if confirmed by feasibility study
4–5	Data center hires local staff; hosting fees and energy sales become real revenue; village becomes a study-tour destination
Ongoing	School programmes, field trips, and open environmental and financial dashboards from Year 1 onward

Economic Value to the Village (Indicative)

Precise figures will come from Phase 1 feasibility studies, but early-stage estimates suggest meaningful local economic value:

- **Energy currently imported**: approximately ¥40–60M per year leaves Mitsue's local economy as electricity payments. Local generation keeps a portion of this value within the village.
- **Closed school maintenance**: currently ¥3–8M per year in upkeep with no return. Active use generates value from a previously stranded asset.
- **Direct employment**: an estimated 8–15 local jobs by Year 5 (forestry, facility operations, EV charging, administration).
- **Landowner income**: new revenue streams for private mountain owners through sustainable cedar harvesting.
- **Combined annual economic activity** by Year 5 (estimated): ¥28–67M, with a meaningful share retained locally.

These ranges are illustrative; the formal numbers will be developed with the village in Phase 1.

What We Are Asking For

At this early stage, we are seeking:

- An **opportunity to discuss** the project with village leadership
- Guidance on how to engage the **community (自治会) and residents** appropriately
- **A letter of interest** to support our application for initial feasibility study funding

We are **not** asking for village funds at this stage.

How the Project Will Be Organized

A dedicated **non-profit organization (NPO法人)** will be established to coordinate the project. The NPO will work transparently with:

- Mitsue Village Government
- Local residents and community associations (自治会)
- Private forest landowners
- Forestry contractors
- Nara Prefecture and national agencies (林野庁, METI)
- Academic and technical partners

Who We Are

Rob Oudendijk — Dutch electrical engineer, Mitsue resident since 2012 (Sugano), core hardware developer for Safecast (the global citizen science radiation monitoring network).

Advisors:

- **Joi Ito** (former Director, MIT Media Lab)
- **Ray Ozzie** (software pioneer, former Microsoft Chief Software Architect)

Our Approach

- **Local first.** Mitsue residents and landowners are the foundation of this project.
- **No surprises.** We will share information openly and seek guidance at every step.
- **Patient and modest.** We are building for 25 years, not for headlines.
- **Replicable.** What we learn in Mitsue will be shared so other villages can benefit.

Next Step

We respectfully request a meeting with village leadership at their convenience to discuss the project and listen to your guidance.

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